That worked! The thing that still has me confused is that Alma insists every digital import profile has an associated default Collection, and it makes that collection the first part of the profile name. Ok, but clearly for an overlay operation the collection is ignored, only the MMS ID (aka the "dc:identifier") is used in our case to identify the correct bib record. Is that documented anywhere?

You're reading the behavior correctly: the default Collection is mandatory on every digital import profile, but when you overlay on existing digital titles via MMS ID, Alma effectively uses the existing bib/collection context and the default Collection becomes irrelevant for those matched records.[107] [108]

What the docs actually say

- Ex Libris states that **every REP must be assigned to a collection** and that you must "define a default collection" in the digital import profile.[107]
- In the bulk-creation examples, they add: if collection fields are not in the incoming metadata, Alma assigns the bib/REP to **"the default collection defined in the MD import profile."**[108]
- For CSV/DC, they note that collection can be supplied explicitly (collection_name / collection_id / collection_external mapped to dc:relation) and that you must add the *"Add BIB to Collection"* normalization rule for the import job to use those fields; **otherwise the default collection is used.**[108]

What's *not* spelled out—but is how your overlay run behaves—is:

- When the import profile **matches an existing bib on 001/MMS ID** and you are not creating a new bib/REP, the existing record's collection membership can remain unchanged; the default Collection parameter is mainly there so Alma knows what to do when it *creates* new digital inventory.[107] [108]

- Because your overlay file contains only the MMS ID and file name, and your normalization doesn't include "Add BIB to Collection," Alma never reassigns these matched bibs to the default Collection—so functionally, the Collection in the profile name is just boilerplate for this workflow.[108]

Why Alma still forces a Collection

Conceptually, Alma treats a **digital import profile** as "create or update digital inventory, and if we must create anything new, it must belong to a Collection," so the UI enforces that field even in pure overlay cases. That design isn't documented as "collection is ignored when overlaying by MMS ID," but you can infer it from the collection-mapping note: if you don't supply collection fields or collection-normalization, Alma falls back to the profile's default only when assigning a collection to *new* records.[107] [108]

If you want a citation-style pointer for colleagues, I'd annotate your local docs roughly as: "Per Ex Libris, a default collection is required for the profile so Alma can assign collections to created records; in our overlay setup we do not create new bibs or change collection fields, so existing collections remain unchanged even though the profile name is prefixed with a collection label." [109] [108] [107]

Is your overlay profile ever going to be reused for *creating* brand-new digital titles, or will you keep it dedicated to the "add JPG to empty REP" workflow only?

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107. https://knowledge.exlibrisgroup.com/Alma/Knowledge_Articles/How_to_Load_Representations_to_an_existing_Alma_Digital_record

108. https://knowledge.exlibrisgroup.com/Alma/Product_Documentation/010Alma_Online_Help_(English)/Digital_Resource_Management/040Creating_Digital_Inventory/040Creating_Digital_Content_in_Bulk

109. https://knowledge.exlibrisgroup.com/Alma/Product_Documentation/010Alma_Online_Help_(English)/040Resource_Management/060Record_Import/020Managing_Import_Profiles